

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Forming extensive networks via mycorrhizal association—that is, a symbiotic relationship between plants and fungi—_____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. it is the entanglement of pine trees’ roots and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake*’s fungal hyphae that makes nutrient transport possible.
- B. the transport of nutrients is possible through the entanglement of pine trees’ roots and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake*’s fungal hyphae.
- C. nutrients can be transported through the entanglement of pine trees’ roots and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake*’s fungal hyphae.
- D. pine trees and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake* can transport nutrients through their entangled tree roots and fungal hyphae.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "pine trees and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake*" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "forming...association." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the pine trees and fungus—and not another noun in the sentence—are forming the networks.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the it-cleft "it is" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically and confusingly suggests that "it" is forming extensive networks. Furthermore, it’s not conventional to follow a long introductory modifying element with an it-cleft construction because it results in an unnecessarily wordy and confusing sentence, such as this. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "the transport of nutrients" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the transport of nutrients is forming extensive networks. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "nutrients" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that nutrients are forming extensive networks.